

Djokovic Battles Back to Beat Zverev at the China Open

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Novak Djokovic came back from a set down to beat **top seed** Alexander Zverev and reach the **semi-finals** of the China Open. Djokovic, a 39-year-old from Serbia, won the **quarter-final** 4-6 6-4 6-4 against Zverev, who is ranked number two in the world.

It was the first time the two had played each other in just under 16 months. At first, Djokovic struggled with Zverev's powerful game. Zverev, who is 29, won the first set after **breaking** Djokovic's serve in the first game. Then Djokovic fought his way back. He broke Zverev's serve at 5-4 in the second set to level the match. The third set was very close. Djokovic broke Zverev again at 5-4 to win. The result hurt Zverev's hopes of finishing the year as the world's number one player.

"These are the kind of moments that I still play for, compete for," Djokovic said. He added that the motivation is big when you are playing well against the best players in front of 15,000 people. "These are the kind of moments that define dreams, I think, of every tennis player."

The win extended Djokovic's **unbeaten** run in Beijing to 32 matches. He is now one step closer to a seventh China Open title and his first trophy of 2026. He has won 24 **Grand Slam** titles, but this year has been a hard one for him, with form and fitness proving challenging. "It's been a struggle this year for different reasons," he said. "But I'm still there, still grinding, still making the youngsters work for their money."

Djokovic will play third seed Daniil Medvedev in the **semi-finals** on Monday. Medvedev beat Francisco Cerundolo in his **quarter-final**. Hubert Hurkacz of Poland also reached the last four.

Word Treasure

semi-finals -- The round with four players left, before the final.

top seed -- The player ranked highest going into a tournament.

break -- Winning a game when the other player is serving.

Grand Slam -- One of the four biggest tennis tournaments.

quarter-final -- The round with eight players left.

unbeaten -- Not having lost.

Break it down

Opening: a comeback win over the top seed

First meeting in almost 16 months and the first set

The comeback in sets two and three

Djokovic's comments

What the win means for the tournament and 2026

The semi-final and other players

Why it matters

The match shows how a veteran champion kept competing at the top level and how results can change the race for the year's top ranking.

Test what you remember

1. Which round did Djokovic win?

- ☐ (A) The final
- ☐ (B) The quarter-final
- ☐ (C) The first round
- ☐ (D) The opening game only

2. What did Djokovic do at 5-4 in the second set?

- ☐ (A) Left the court
- ☐ (B) Asked for a break
- ☐ (C) Won a point with a lob
- ☐ (D) Broke Zverev's serve to level the match

3. What did the result hurt?

- ☐ (A) Djokovic's plan to retire
- ☐ (B) The tournament's schedule
- ☐ (C) The crowd's mood
- ☐ (D) Zverev's hopes of finishing the year as world number one

4. How many matches long is Djokovic's unbeaten run in Beijing?

- ☐ (A) 24
- ☐ (B) 7
- ☐ (C) 32
- ☐ (D) 15

5. What trophy has Djokovic not yet won in 2026?

- ☐ (A) A doubles trophy
- ☐ (B) Any trophy this year
- ☐ (C) The Beijing noodle cup
- ☐ (D) The Grand Slam in London

6. Which other player also reached the last four?

- ☐ (A) Hubert Hurkacz of Poland
- ☐ (B) Carlos Alcaraz
- ☐ (C) Karen Khachanov
- ☐ (D) Francisco Cerundolo

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: D 4: C 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Novak Djokovic: Said these are the kind of moments he still plays for, and that it has been a struggle this year.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):